



### Skydio and EagleView team up

Skydio have partnered with EagleView for autonomous residential roof inspections via drones. <http://dgit.in/oct20-19>



### Uber can continue in London

The popular ride-hailing company was taken to court for not being "fit and proper". <http://dgit.in/oct20-20>

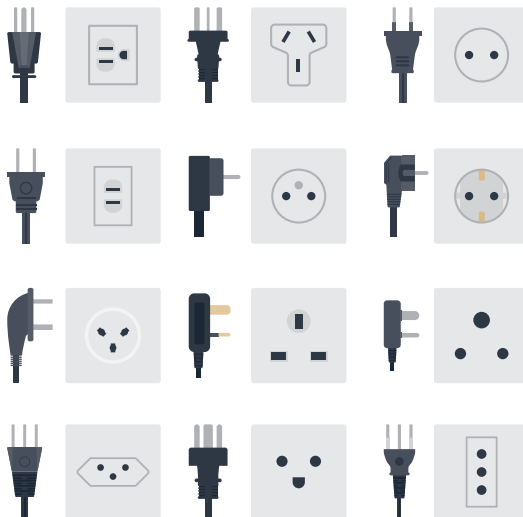
## ORIGINS

Now, in the midst of this war, countries already began developing plugs and sockets to harness electricity for the household and no one was really checking on global standardisation practices. Instead, country-wise standardisation practices began in full earnest. Westinghouse Electric settled on an easy standard: 60Hz and 110V. On the other hand, in Germany, the standardisation was done by one company, BEW, that had a monopoly on electricity and selected 50Hz as their standard. It also chose to supply its customers with additional power by raising their standards from 110V to 220V in 1899. This spread across Europe over the next few decades.

It was suggested that the US make the shift to the 220-volt system in the 1950s, however, the consumers across the country already had a number of 120V products and making the shift did not make sense. Instead, the US employed Edison's three-wire system, where one wire supplied +120V, the other supplied 0V, while the third one supplied -120V. In this way, stoves, washers, and other large appliances could access 220V while smaller ones could operate on 120V.

### THE CYCLE OF NON-STANDARDISED PLUGS AND SOCKETS

Decades after the first standards, new electrical devices had to be patched



Different types of plugs and sockets

directly into your house's wiring, which is something that may seem implausible or even scary to us today. However, there was no convenient way of tapping into the electrical power for anything other than lighting. Then came Harvey Hubbell's 'Separable Attachment Plug' which allowed for even non-lighting devices to be plugged into 'light' sockets to derive power from. This plug has to be wired to the appliance, and users would no longer have to live with live wires being connected to their house.

After this invention by Hubbell, the next development came in 1928 when Philip F. Labre added a third ground prong to the plug which could be inserted into a third hole in the socket to reduce electrical shock as a result of a short circuit. The third prong acted as an alternative path the electricity could travel through in case of a short circuit, instead of the human itself. This is the model that is still utilised in modern-day outlets where apart from the ground prong, two prongs connect to the live and neutral wires. Now, across the world, there are some plugs that feature different-sized prongs, some are set at different angles, while some even have completely different shapes.

There was a need felt, however, to set international standards for plugs and sockets in order to share electric innovations in a standardised manner. Thus, the International Electro-technical Commission (IEC) came into existence with the goal to unite forces and create an international standard. However, the development of different plugs across countries was in full swing and the IEC could exert minimal, if any, authority over this as a non-profit organisation. Additionally, the advent of World

War II shattered what little progress they did make as well. After the war, Europe's resources were depleted to a bare minimum and they essentially had to start from near scratch. When they started back up again, they went ahead and designed an efficient plug and outlet, however, it was completely different yet again, and thus continued the saga of non-standardised plugs and sockets.

Additionally, Britain spent a considerable amount of its time in history influencing India during the



Harvey Hubbell's Separable Attachment Plug

Image source: Digital Museum of Plugs and Sockets

colonisation period. Therefore, when Britain first began developing their plugs and outlets, they implemented the same standards in India as well. However, after we gained freedom in 1947, the newer, updated versions of outlets that are currently used in the UK were never implemented in our country. We still continue to use the older versions of the British power outlets, even today. There are other cases as well such as Israel which has its own standard that is used nowhere else in the entire world. On the other hand, El Salvador, with no national standard, is currently juggling ten different electrical standards! Every country is extremely invested in their own system and it is laboriously hard to stray away from that at this stage. The prospect of there ever being an international standard may only come into fruition if a radically-different technology surfaces that causes everyone to switch to that. Nevertheless, despite the chaotic system, electrical plugs and sockets are integral innovations that have played a significant role in catapulting us into the technologically-advanced society we are today. 🇮🇳